

The Simple Blueprint

Your Essential Guide to Senior Transitions



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RIGGINS STRATEGIC SOLUTIONS

*"I switched sides to help families do this the right way.
This guide is where to start."*

The essential starting guide for families managing a senior's move.

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Welcome to Your Simple Blueprint

This guide gives you the essential frameworks, checklists, and decision-making tools to handle a senior transition without getting overwhelmed or taken advantage of. It is the map: the whole path, the smart moves, and the traps to avoid, so you can take action right away.

Who this is for: families who want to run the transition themselves with a professional framework in their corner, without paying for full-service coordination.

The Map, and the System

This free guide is your map. When you want the turn-by-turn, here is how it stacks up:

	What you get
This guide (free)	The frameworks, the key decisions, and the checklists. Enough to start today and avoid the biggest mistakes.
The Senior Transition Blueprint (\$47)	All 20 in-depth modules, 69 fillable tools and interactive calculators that do the work for you, video lessons, and the member portal.
The Senior Transition Roadmap (\$297)	Everything in the \$47 Blueprint, plus a plan built around your family, a 60-minute call with Ryan, and 90 days of priority email support.

Start free at rigginsstrategicsolutions.com/blueprint.

Free Companion Tools

This guide references calculators and worksheets you can use free at rigginsstrategicsolutions.com:

- Net Proceeds Calculator
- Strategic Exit Engine
- Home Prep Quiz
- Transition Readiness Assessment
- Beneficiary Designation Audit
- Caregiver Burnout Quiz
- Aging in Place Break-Even Tool
- Medicare Gap Analyzer
- \$5K Smart Prep Budget Calculator

How to Use This Guide

- [] Read through once for the big picture before diving into any one section.
- [] Assess your stage honestly (Early Planning, Preparing to Move, or Urgent Transition).
- [] Focus on the sections that apply to your situation right now.
- [] Print the checklists and work through them.
- [] Keep this as your reference for the whole transition.

Estimated time to complete a transition: 2 to 6 months, depending on your timeline and complexity.

Module 0: Quick Start and Orientation

The 7-Day Quick Start Plan

If you are just starting and feel overwhelmed, follow this simple 7-day plan to build momentum.

Day	Focus	Do This
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Day 1	Assess your situation	Answer the 6 Foundational Questions below. Identify your timeline. List who is helping.
Day 2	Build your support team	Name the primary decision-maker. List family who will help. Note which professionals you will need.
Day 3	Set your first milestone	Pick ONE small area to declutter. Schedule 2 hours. Celebrate the win.
Day 4	Safety-first walk	Walk the home for fall hazards. Fix the top 3 this week.
Day 5	Research the next home	Look at 3 community options online, or price modifications if aging in place.
Day 6	Financial reality check	Ballpark the home value (Zillow, Redfin). List monthly expenses. Rough out transition costs.
Day 7	Build your timeline	Mark a target move date. Work backward to set milestones. Plan next week.

The 6 Foundational Questions

Answer these six before you dive in. They shape your entire approach. Keep your answers handy.

- **1. WHY is this happening?** Safety, isolation, health decline, finances, proactive planning, or family pressure.
- **2. WHO makes the decisions?** The senior, the family, shared, or the Power of Attorney.
- **3. WHEN does this need to happen?** No rush (1 to 5+ years), a general window (6 to 12 months), or urgent (0 to 3 months).
- **4. WHERE is the senior going?** Independent living, assisted living, memory care, downsizing, aging in place, or in with family.
- **5. WHAT support do you have?** Family nearby, family out of state, or none, and how much time you have.
- **6. HOW much can you spend?** Home sale proceeds, savings, and whether the budget is flexible or tight.

Module 1: Your New Starting Point

Every transition falls into one of three stages. Find yours and match your effort to it.

Stage 1: Early Planning (1 to 5+ years out)

Focus on: gradual decluttering (2 bags a week), building savings, researching communities, early family conversations, and getting estate documents in order. **Don't worry yet about:** detailed move planning, vendor selection, or urgent repairs.

Stage 2: Preparing to Move (3 to 12 months out)

Focus on: systematic room-by-room decluttering, community tours, home prep and repairs, vendor research, financial planning, and dividing tasks across the family.

Stage 3: Urgent Transition (0 to 3 months)

Focus on: safety first, selling the home as-is (do not waste time on repairs), hiring professionals, aggressive downsizing to essentials, and a community with immediate availability.

The Fear Inventory

Transitions bring fear. Name them and they shrink. Common ones: making the wrong decision, losing independence, family conflict, running out of money, the senior's resistance, an overwhelming workload, and missing something important.

For each fear, ask: Is it based on facts or assumptions? What is the worst that could happen? The best? The most likely? What can I control, and what must I accept? Most fears shrink when you examine them closely.

Module 2: The Decluttering Phase

The 5-Pile Sorting System

Every item goes into exactly one of five piles. Touch it once, decide, move on.

Pile	Criteria	What to do
1. Keep	Used in the last 6 months, brings genuine joy, or essential	Moving forward with you
2. Donate	Functional, clean, in good condition, not needed	Schedule a charity pickup; get a tax receipt
3. Sell	Worth \$50 or more and you have time to sell	Estate sale or marketplace
4. Trash	Broken, damaged, expired, unusable	Toss it, no guilt
5. Decide Later	Sentimental or uncertain	Limit to 10% of items; revisit in 2 weeks

The 3-second rule: if you cannot decide in three seconds, it goes in Pile 5. Come back to those in two weeks with fresh eyes. Most of that pile becomes Donate or Trash.

The Two-Bag Daily Tidy (for Stage 1)

Every day, fill two bags: one to donate (3 to 5 items) and one to trash (3 to 5 items). Remove them from the home immediately.

- In 30 days: 60 to 100 items removed = real progress.
- In 90 days: 180 to 300 items removed = a transformed home.

Early Wins Checklist

Start with easy, low-emotion areas for quick momentum:

- ☐ Kitchen junk drawer
- ☐ Medicine cabinet (check expiration dates)
- ☐ Coat closet
- ☐ Garage or shed (broken tools, empty containers)
- ☐ Linen closet (old towels, sheets)
- ☐ Bathroom cabinets
- ☐ Entryway

Module 3: Sorting and Categorizing

Work through the home one room at a time. Recommended order: guest room or least-used space first, then storage areas, bathrooms, kitchen, bedrooms, living spaces, and sentimental items last.

For each room: empty it if you can, clean the space, sort with the 5-Pile System, return only the Keep items, and remove the other piles immediately. Budget 2 to 8 hours per room.

The 3-Path System for Sentimental Items

Sentimental items are the hardest. Use this framework so they do not stall you out.

Path	What it is	How much	The rule
1. Photograph and Release	Take a photo, write the memory, let the object go	About 80%	Keep the memory, not the object
2. Display and Enjoy	Items that truly bring joy, displayed in the new home	About 15%	Limit to what fits

3. Archive	Truly irreplaceable items, one box per person	About 5%	For future generations
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Rule of thumb: if you have not looked at it in 10+ years, use Path 1.

Paperwork: The 3-Folder Method

Every paper goes into one of three folders.

Folder	What goes here	Examples
1. Active	Needed within a year	Current tax returns, active insurance, current medical records, active bills
2. Archive	Legally required to keep	Last 7 years of taxes, property deed, birth certificates, wills, trusts, POA documents
3. Shred	Everything else	Old statements, outdated policies, tax returns over 7 years, expired warranties

Protect against ID theft: shred anything with a Social Security number, an account number, or a medical detail. Do not just throw it in the trash.

Module 4: Rightsizing the Home

Space-Planning Reality Check

Measure the new home and your KEEP furniture before you move a thing. Living room ____ ft x ____ ft. Bedroom ____ ft x ____ ft. Total square footage _____. Then measure your biggest pieces (sofa, bed, dining table).

If it does not fit, you have three options: do not take it (donate, sell, gift), replace it with a smaller version, or choose a different new home. Most furniture will not fit. Accept that early.

The Two-Week Wardrobe Test

Most people wear 20% of their clothes 80% of the time. Weeks 1 to 2, wear only what you actually reach for and mark those items. Week 3, everything unmarked gets donated (keep 1 to 2 special-occasion outfits). Result: a wardrobe cut by 60 to 80%.

Furniture Decision (ask five things)

Will it fit the new space? Is it in good condition? Will the senior actually use it? Is it safe (no trip hazards)? Does the senior love it? **4 to 5 yes = keep. 2 to 3 = maybe, test it in the layout. 0 to 1 = do not take it.**

Module 5: Safety, Repairs and Smart Upgrades

Home Safety Assessment (do this first)

Walk the home and check for fall hazards (loose rugs, clutter on stairs, poor lighting, uneven floors, missing handrails), bathroom safety (grab bars, non-slip mats, a raised toilet seat), and kitchen safety (heavy items up high, a working stove, an accessible fire extinguisher). Fix safety first. Everything else is secondary.

Ryan's "What NOT to Fix" List

Most families waste \$50K to \$100K on repairs that do not pay back. Skip the big projects and do the smart, cheap version instead.

Do NOT do this	Cost	Do this instead	Cost
Full kitchen remodel	\$40K	Cabinet paint	\$1,500
Luxury flooring	\$20K	Professional cleaning	\$300

Instagram / HGTV staging	\$10K	Declutter and neutral paint	\$2K
Replace functional appliances	\$4,500	Deep clean	\$0
Structural wall removal	\$15K	Leave it	\$0

Total saved by skipping the big stuff: about \$85K to \$90K. When in doubt, do not fix it, sell as-is instead.

Do FIX these (if selling)

Safety issues, fresh neutral paint, a deep clean, curb appeal (landscaping, front door), and obvious repairs (broken windows, leaky faucets). Budget of \$2K to \$5K is usually plenty.

The ROI Rule

For each repair, ask: will this return more than it costs? **High return (do these):** fresh paint (~150%), professional cleaning (~300%), curb appeal (~100%), cabinet refresh (~200%). **Low return (skip these):** full kitchen remodel (30 to 50%), bathroom remodel (~50%), luxury upgrades (15 to 30%).

Module 6: Financial and Legal Preparation

Estimating Transition Costs

Cost category	Typical range	Your estimate
Moving costs	\$3,000 - \$8,000	\$_____
Home preparation	\$2,000 - \$5,000	\$_____
Legal / professional fees	\$3,000 - \$5,000	\$_____
Overlap costs (two homes at once)	\$5,000 - \$15,000	\$_____
Contingency (10%)	-	\$_____
TOTAL ESTIMATE	\$15,000 - \$40,000	\$_____

Source of funds: home sale proceeds, savings, family contributions, a bridge loan, or (with caution) a reverse mortgage.

The Four Must-Have Documents

- **Will:** specifies who gets your assets, names an executor and guardians.
- **Financial Power of Attorney:** lets someone handle finances if you are incapacitated. Without it, the family goes to court.
- **Healthcare Power of Attorney:** lets someone make medical decisions. Without it, doctors may not share information with family.
- **Living Will / Advance Directive:** states your end-of-life wishes so family does not have to guess

The forgotten detail, beneficiary designations. Life insurance, 401(k)s, IRAs, and bank accounts have beneficiary designations that OVERRIDE your will. If your 401(k) still lists an ex-spouse from 20 years ago, the ex gets it, no matter what the will says. Update them after any marriage, divorce, birth, or death.

When to Consult a Professional

Professional	When to use	Cost
Estate Attorney	Wills, trusts, powers of attorney	\$2,000 - \$5,000
Financial Planner	Retirement withdrawals, tax implications	\$1,500 - \$3,000

CPA	Tax planning around asset sales	\$500 - \$2,000
Elder Law Attorney	Medicaid planning, long-term care funding	\$3,000 - \$7,000

Do not DIY complex estate planning. Get expert help.

Module 7: Senior Community Exploration

Type	Description	Care level	Cost / month
Independent Living	Active seniors, minimal help; meals, housekeeping, activities	Minimal	\$2,000 - \$5,000
Assisted Living	Help with daily activities, 24-hour staff	Moderate	\$3,500 - \$7,000
Memory Care	Specialized for dementia or Alzheimer's, secure environment	High	\$5,000 - \$10,000
Nursing Home	Highest level of medical care	Very High	\$7,000 - \$12,000

What to Look For When Touring

First impressions (clean, friendly staff, happy residents, fresh smell), the food (tour the dining room, sample a meal), activities (a real calendar, engaged residents), staff (good ratio, low turnover), and costs (all-inclusive or add-ons, extra fees for care levels).

Red Flags

- High-pressure sales
- Won't let you tour unannounced
- Residents seem unhappy
- Bad smells
- Overwhelmed staff
- Vague about costs
- Bad online reviews

Trust your gut. If something feels off, it probably is.

Module 8: Estate Planning Essentials

Medicaid Planning Basics

If you might need Medicaid for long-term care someday, you have to plan ahead. Medicaid has strict asset and income limits and a 5-year "look-back." It reviews transfers of assets in the last 5 years, gifts to family, property sold below market value, and transferred bank accounts.

Before you do anything, consult an elder law attorney. Do not accidentally disqualify yourself. Cost of the attorney: \$2,000 to \$5,000. Cost of the mistake: Medicaid ineligibility running into hundreds of thousands. It is worth the investment.

The Digital Estate Plan

Do not forget your digital life. Make a list of email accounts, social media, online banking and financial accounts, subscriptions, cloud storage, and digital photos. Store it securely (note where the passwords are kept, not the passwords themselves) and tell your Power of Attorney where to find it.

Module 9: Home Sale Strategy

The 7 Exit Strategies

Most people think there is only one way to sell a home. There are seven, and the right one depends on your timeline, the home's condition, and your goals.

Strategy	Best for	Timeline	Pros	Cons
1. Traditional MLS	Homes in good condition	30-60 days	Highest price	Requires prep and showings
2. As-Is Sale	Urgent, poorer condition	30-45 days	No repairs needed	Lower price
3. Cash Investor	Urgent, need it fast	7-14 days	Fast, no repairs	Lowest price (60-70% of value)
4. Owner Financing	Buyer can't get a loan	Flexible	Higher price, monthly income	Delayed full payout
5. Lease-Option	Slow market, want income	Flexible	Monthly income, future sale	Tenant risk
6. 1031 Exchange	Tax-deferred reinvest	45-180 days	Defer capital gains tax	Must reinvest in property
7. Keep as Rental	Passive income	Ongoing	Monthly cash flow	Landlord responsibilities

Most families default to Strategy 1 without ever considering the others.

Pricing and Negotiation

The 3-tier pricing model: aggressive (5 to 10% below market, generates multiple offers, sells fast); market price (attracts serious buyers, sells in 30 to 60 days); premium (5 to 10% above, tests the market, may sit). **Ryan's take:** price at market or slightly below. Overpricing costs you time and money.

The 3 levers in every negotiation: price (what they pay), terms (closing date, contingencies, repairs), and timing (move-out flexibility). You cannot win all three, decide which matters most and be willing to give on the others.

Module 10: Move Management and Coordination

The T-Minus Timeline

When	Do this
T-minus 30 days	Book movers. Order packing supplies. Begin packing non-essentials. Notify utilities. Submit change of address.
T-minus 14 days	Confirm all vendors. Pack 70-80% of belongings. Label boxes clearly. Prepare the essentials box for the first 24 hours.
T-minus 7 days	Finalize packing (90-95%). Reconfirm movers. Empty storage areas. Do a final walkthrough of the new home.
T-minus 1 day	Pack everything but bare essentials. Charge all devices. Print the move-day plan. Get good sleep.
Move day	Supervise movers. Check off inventory. Final walkthrough of the old home. Direct placement at the new home.

The Move-Day Bag (keep it in your car, not on the truck): important documents (IDs, insurance, medical records), medications, valuables, phone chargers, a change of clothes, toiletries, snacks and water, and cash.

Module 11: Final Move-Out and Home Transition

The Final Walkthrough

- ☐ All personal belongings removed
- ☐ All trash and debris removed
- ☐ All appliances clean (if leaving them)

- ☐ All light fixtures working
- ☐ All windows and doors locked
- ☐ Thermostat set appropriately
- ☐ Garage door opener left (if applicable)
- ☐ Keys and remotes ready to hand over

Utility Shut-Off

Schedule electric, gas, water, internet/cable, trash, and security to shut off. **Do not shut off utilities until AFTER closing**, the buyer's walkthrough and inspection need them on.

Module 12: Settling Into the New Home

The First 30 Days

- **Week 1 (essentials):** unpack the essentials box, set up the bed and bathroom, stock kitchen basics, locate exits and the fire extinguisher.
- **Week 2 (functionality):** unpack the kitchen and bedroom, set up living spaces, hang pictures.
- **Week 3 (routine):** establish a daily rhythm, meet neighbors, find local services (pharmacy, grocery).
- **Week 4 (connection):** attend activities, join a club, invite family, celebrate the transition

The first 90 days are the most important for building social connections. Introduce yourself to neighbors, attend a few events, join one ongoing activity, and eat in the dining room if there is one. Isolation is the enemy. Connection is the goal.

Module 13: Family Communication and Reducing Stress

The Family Meeting Framework

Before: set a clear agenda, share it in advance, assign a note-taker, set a time limit. **During:** start with positives, take concerns one at a time, make decisions (do not just discuss), assign action items with deadlines. **After:** send a summary, schedule the next meeting, follow up on commitments.

When Family Members Disagree

Separate the person from the problem, attack the issue not each other. Listen to understand, not to respond; everyone needs to feel heard. Focus on shared goals, you all want what is best for the senior. Compromise where you can, and once a decision is made, move forward, do not relitigate it.

Self-Care for Caregivers

You cannot pour from an empty cup. Schedule breaks, ask for help, set boundaries, keep your own health appointments, connect with other caregivers, and consider respite care if you need it. Taking care of yourself is not selfish, it is necessary.

Quick Reference Checklists

Decluttering

- ☐ Start with easy wins (junk drawer, medicine cabinet)
- ☐ Use the 5-Pile System
- ☐ Work room by room
- ☐ Use the 3-second rule for decisions

Home Prep

- ☐ Safety assessment complete
- ☐ Fresh neutral paint
- ☐ Deep cleaning
- ☐ Curb appeal improvements
- ☐ Obvious repairs completed

Moving Day

- ☐ Move-day bag packed
- ☐ Movers confirmed
- ☐ Utilities scheduled
- ☐ Final walkthrough complete
- ☐ Keys and remotes ready

Ready for the Complete System?

You now have the map, the frameworks, the checklists, and the key decisions. When you want the turn-by-turn version that does the work with you, here is where to go.

The Senior Transition Blueprint — \$47

Everything in this Simple Blueprint, plus all 20 in-depth modules, our complete library of 69 downloadable tools and interactive calculators, video lessons, the online member portal, and detailed vendor vetting guides. Get instant access at rigginsstrategicsolutions.com/blueprint.

The Senior Transition Roadmap — \$297

Everything in the \$47 Blueprint, plus a personalized transition plan built around your specific situation, a 60-minute coaching call with Ryan, and 90 days of priority email support.

SeniorSafe App — 14-day free trial

Coordinate your family with daily check-ins, an AI assistant, a secure document vault, medication tracking, and family messaging. After the trial: \$14.99/mo Premium. or \$39.99/mo Premium+. Start at seniorsafeapp.com.

Have questions? Text Ryan directly at (336) 553-8933. He reads and responds to every message.

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